



*English  
Literature*

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# **INTRODUCTION**

English literature is a vast and rich field of study that spans centuries, encompassing a diverse array of genres, themes, and authors. From the epic tales of Beowulf in the Anglo-Saxon period to the contemporary works of modern-day writers, English literature offers a window into the cultural, social, and historical contexts of the times in which these works were produced.

One of the defining features of English literature is its evolution over time. Each period of literature, from the medieval and Renaissance eras to the Romantic and Victorian periods, reflects the changing values, beliefs, and experiences of society. This literary journey includes the works of iconic figures such as William Shakespeare, whose plays and sonnets have left an indelible mark on the literary landscape; the Romantic poets like William Wordsworth and Samuel Taylor Coleridge, who explored the depths of human emotion and the beauty of nature; and the novelists of the Victorian era, including Charles Dickens and the Brontë sisters, who depicted the complexities of social class and the human condition.

Studying English literature not only enriches our understanding of the past but also enhances our appreciation of the beauty and power of language. It encourages critical thinking, empathy, and a deeper awareness of human experience. Whether one is delving into the allegorical worlds of medieval literature, the profound insights of modernist texts, or the innovative storytelling of contemporary authors, English literature continues to inspire and captivate readers around the world.

## **ACKNOWLEDGEMENT**

I would like to express my deepest gratitude to all those who provided me with the possibility to complete this project on English literature.

First and foremost, I am extremely grateful to [TA] English Literature Madam for their invaluable guidance, support, and insightful feedback throughout the course of this project. Their expertise and dedication have been a tremendous source of inspiration and encouragement.

I would also like to extend my heartfelt thanks to the librarian of Kekirawa Public Library where resources and facilities were indispensable in carrying out my research. I am particularly thankful to the library staff for their assistance in locating and accessing relevant materials.

My sincere appreciation goes to my family and friends for their continuous support and encouragement. Their patience and understanding during the many hours I dedicated to this project were truly invaluable.

Lastly, I would like to acknowledge the authors and scholars whose works have enriched my understanding of English literature and significantly contributed to this project. Their contributions have provided a solid foundation upon which I have built my analysis.

Thank you all for your unwavering support and guidance.



## **POETRY**

### **Sri Lankan English Poets**

1. Vivimarie Vanderpoorten
2. Lakdas Wikkramasinha
3. Kamala Wijeratne
4. Anne Ranasinghe
5. Jean Arasanayagam



- **Anne Ranasinghe**



Anne Ranasinghe (born Anneliese Katz, 2 October 1925 – 17 December 2016) was a Jewish-German born, Sri Lankan English language poet. She is considered as one of Sri Lanka's leading poet in English, having won several international awards.

#### Early Life

Anneliese Katz was born in 2 October 1925 in Essen, Germany, to a Jewish family. A victim of Nazi Germany's atrocities against Jews, she witnessed the Kristallnacht (night of broken glass), the burning of the Essen synagogue. In 1939, her parents sent her to England as an alien she had never seen before. Within a week, she was sent to a school 160 miles away to live among strangers and to learn English, a new language to her. Within six months World War II broke out and much later she would learn that her parents had been murdered by the Nazis.

Anne completed her studies at Parkstone Grammar School and trained to become a nursing sister at Charing Cross Hospital, King's College, Moorfields, Chelsea and Burden Neurological Institute.

#### Literary Work

Ranasinghe began her writing career in the late 1960s after obtaining a Diploma in Journalism from Colombo Technical College. In 1971, she published her first poem collection, "And the Sun that Sucks the Earth to Dry." Some of Ranasinghe's well-known poems include: "July 1983," "Plead Mercy (1974)," "Long Hot Day," and "At What Dark Point (1970)." She has published 12 books and have been translated into several languages in seven countries.

#### Recognition

Ranasinghe was awarded Sri Lanka Arts Council Prize for Poetry in 1985 and again in 1992 and also for non-fiction in 1987. She won the Sri Lankan State Literary Award for best collection of short stories in 1994. She was awarded the 'Order of Merit of the Federal Republic of Germany,' the nation's only federal civilian award.



- **Jean Arasanayagam**



Jean Arasanayagam (b. 1931, née Solomon) is arguably Sri Lanka's most widely read and anthologized poet publishing in the English language. She is of Dutch-Burgher origin and along with because [sic, possibly a grammatical error in the original text, but likely meant "her husband and daughter"] Parvathi forms one of Sri Lanka's most reputed writer-families. Best known as a poet, Jean is also a writer of short fiction, fiction and memoirs. Her writing in all genres are marked with a distinct and powerful biographical element.

Among Jean's more memorable collections of poetry are interventions she makes on matters of identity, heritage, displacement, fragmentation and ethnic politics. In particular, her collection "Apocalypse 83 (1984)" was a turning point in her career as a poet and remains to date her most widely quoted work for its acute political sensitivity, strong line of protest against anti-Tamil violence of post-independence and the focus it specifically lays on the riots of July 1983.

Jean has also written extensively of her own identity displacement as a Dutch Burgher in a post-colonial world which is further complicated by her marriage to a traditional Jaffna Tamil family. Among her 40-odd titles are poetry collections such as *Kindura* (1973), *Poems of Season Beginning and a Season Over* (1977), *Apocalypse 83* (1984), "A Colonial's Encounter and Other Poems (1986)", "Out of Our Prisons: We Emerge (1987), *Trial by Terror* (1991), *Reddened Waters Flow Clear* (1991), *Shooting the Floricans* (1993), *Fussilade* (2002), *Missed Zones* (2010). Her more recent work displays a penchant for revision and introspection. She was awarded the Gratiaen Prize in 2017 for her collection, *The Life of a Poet*.

## **Plead Mercy**

(Sabbe Sattha Bhavanthu Sukhi Thaththa)

We pass a bullock yoked to a cart  
Straining uphill. He shivers  
With effort, his bones  
Protrude and the taut skin quiver  
At each whip of sharp - thorned stick  
There is no expression on his face  
Only his eyes plead mercy  
Foam slavers from his lips  
As he travails to increase his pace  
And slips. My daughter asks  
Does he think life is worth living?

I tell her what I know  
Is not true, that life  
Is always better than death  
She frowns  
If there is revolution, she says  
I'll kill myself. All those horrible things  
They do to people  
The bullock has fallen on the rough  
Edge of the road, He tries  
But in spite of the  
Stick he cannot rise  
Lord have mercy on his eyes  
My daughter is just thirteen.

**Anne Ranasinghe**

## Poem – My Dream

### My Dreams

I dream to fly beyond the sky,  
To touch the stars that shine so high.  
To paint the world in colors bright,  
And fill each day with hope and light.

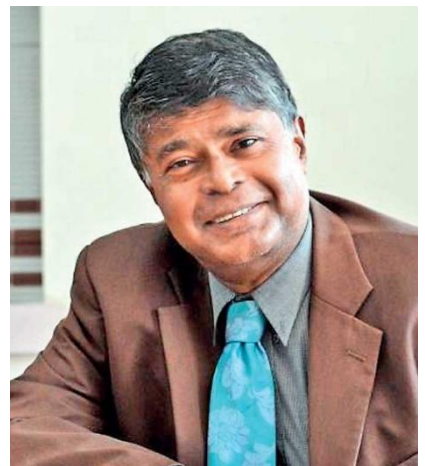
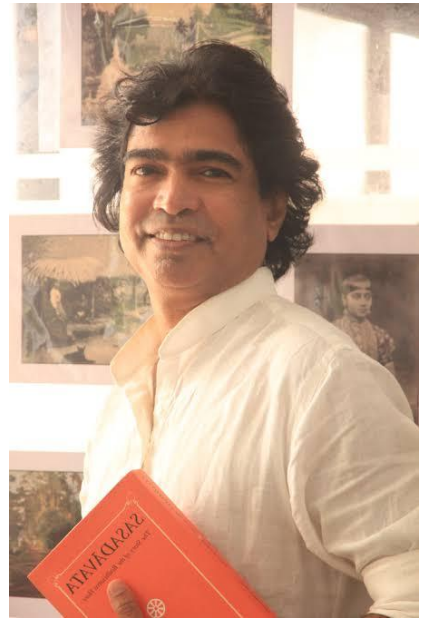
I dream to learn, to laugh, to grow,  
To help the world and kindness show.  
Though small I am, my dreams are wide,  
With strength and love I keep my stride.

*My Dream*

## **SHORT STORY**

### **Sri Lankan English Short Story Writers**

1. D.C.R.A. Goonetilleke
2. Punyakanti Wijenayake
3. Yasmine Gooneratne
4. Chithra Frenando
5. Shyam Selvadurai
6. Amanda Jayatissa
7. Lal Medawattegedara
8. Rajiva Wijesingha



- **Rajiva wijesingha**



Rajiva Wijesinha (b.1954) is the author of *Servants* (1995) and *An English Education* (1996) and best acknowledged within the sphere of English writing in Sri Lanka as an editor of several literature anthologies and a promoter of home writing within and outside the country. He is a Renaissance-like presence in multifaceted fields—education, literature, diplomacy, politics—as well as in his classical erudition which often comes to light through his writing.

Wijesinha was schooled at St. Thomas' College, Mount Lavinia and University College, Oxford, and has been an academic at the University of Peradeniya and the Sabaragamuwa University of Sri Lanka. He resigned his position from the former institute in what is considered to be a mark of protest against the growing authoritarianism of the JR Jayewardena regime in the early-1980s. Much later, in the mid-1990s, he was a crucial figure in the formative years of the Sabaragamuwa University, which he continued to serve until 2015. He has worked to uplift the level of English education catering to students from non-English speaking backgrounds and in the early-90s he spearheaded several such programmes oriented towards university entrants. He was a steering force behind the reintroduction of English medium education into Sri Lankan high schools in 2001. Wijesinha has also served the British Council in its Cultural Affairs Department and been a linchpin in its cultural and literary incentives in the early-90s.

Wijesinha's early work includes *Acts of Faith* (1985) written midway of President Jayewardena's 11 year term (1977-1988), *Days of Despair* (1989) and *The Lady Hippopotamus* (1991). His work is often charged with political criticism and undermining of establishmentarian corruption, be it the government (as in *Acts of Faith*, *Days of Despair* and *The Limits of Love*) or an institute such as the university, as seen in *An English Education* (1996).

His *Servants* (1995) – later translated into Italian – was awarded the second edition of the Gratiaen Prize in 1994. Wijesinha is also instrumental in the preservation and publication of the works of Richard de Zoysa – his personal friend – whose poetry Wijesinha anthologized in 2000, as *Richard de Zoysa: his life, some work ... a death*. Given to be understood as a memoir, *The Limits of Love* (2005) is woven around the life and death of Richard de Zoysa. de Zoysa was a journalist, a human rights activist, a writer, dramatist and television anchor whom Wijesinha had known from his high school years, who was abducted and killed by the then-government's paramilitary in February, 1990.

Wijesinha is also an editor who has anthologized poetry and short fiction, noted for collections such as *A Selection of English Poetry* (1997?), *Bridging Connections: Sri Lankan Short Stories* (2007), *A Selection of Modern Sri Lankan Poetry in English* (2006) and *A Selection of Modern Sri Lankan Short Stories in English* (2005), which was co-edited with Dinali Fernando. He has also served in the Editorial Panel of the English Writers' Cooperative (EWC) which he assisted the formation of, as a forum of promoting the work of Lankan writers and in building up a discourse of production and reception.

Wijesinha was a founding member of the Council for Liberal Democracy set up in 1982 and of the Liberal Party of Sri Lanka, of which he is at present the leader since the death of its founder leader Chanaka Amaratunga. He has also been a parliamentarian from 2010 to 2015, and bearer of the portfolio of State Minister of Higher Education for a brief period in 2015.



- **Punyakanti Wijenayake**



Punyakanti Wijenaike (b.1933) is a Sri Lankan writer of fiction, short story, and poetry. Born to colonial Ceylon, she is among the first generation of Ceylonese/Sri Lanka's post-independence literati, and her early compositions coincide with cultural, social, and political changes and upheaval that were instrumental in the shaping of a 'new' nation in times post-1956.

Wijenaike has lived most of her life in Colombo and hails from an upper-middle social background. Her first collection of short stories was 'The Third Woman' (1963), which she followed up with her novels, which include *The Waiting Earth* (1966), *Giraya* (1971), *Amulet* (1994), *An Enemy Within* (1998), and *When the Harvest is Over* (2013).

She has won the Women of Achievement Award in 1985, the Kala Suri Class 1 (literary achievement) conferred by the Government of Sri Lanka in 1988, the 1994 Gratiaen Prize for her novel *Amulet* and has been felicitated as the joint winner of the Commonwealth Short Story Competition for Radio in 1996.

## Monkeys – Punyakanthie Wijenayake

This short story narrates the life of a young Samanera (novice monk in training) and his love towards the monkeys in the forest nearby which he visits every afternoon. The boy carries a bit of food with him every time he spends time with the monkeys. At the play with them. Love, is what he experiences every time he spends time with the monkeys. At the time of departure he hates leaving the monkeys as he has to go back and complete the chores at the hermitage. Waking up early at 4 every morning to meditate and then complete the chores only to leave later on to beg for food and then come back to meditate and then to the monkeys. This was the monotonous life he led every day. The thought of being a monkey seemed to please him as the love bestowed by the monkeys shared between themselves is what he longed for.

One night, as he was bathing he saw his own reflection in the water to be that of a monkey, only to realize after disturbing the still water his own reflection just a trick of the water. To be that of a monkey, only to realize after disturbing the still water his own reflection just a trick of the water. Later, when the boy was sweeping the compound with a broom, he noticed that the same monkeys had followed him there and were sitting on the treetops.

The same monkeys, in hordes, had followed him to the hermitage and this time they boldly started jumping and running in hordes, had followed him to the hermitage and this time they boldly started jumping and running in the hermitage disturbing the priests. And this time they boldly started jumping and running in the hermitage disturbing the priests and this time they created a havoc by throwing the fruits grown by the chief priest around and ringing the temple bells.

After this incident, the Chief Priest led the young Samanera to an inner room. He made him understand the difference between men and animals and other human beings. At the end of the story the life of a Samanera differed from the trees for the last time and turns away, as now he must remember that after all he is a man. And the trees for the last time and turns away, as now he must remember that after all he is a man.

The prevalent themes in the poem are love and humanity. Through out the poem love acts as a constant as the young boy craves it but never shows it. The life involved in leading such a life are ones to be thought of very carefully. Abandoning the essence of human life ie love, to break the cycle of rebirth seems to be the effective conclusion of the life of a Samanera.

As the boy longed for love, he had to be told in the end that it is not the kind of life he could lead. Having peace within oneself is what is necessary compared to love and other petty functions of life.

# **DRAMA**

## **Sinhabhahu**

Long ago in India there lived a beautiful princess.

One day, she was travelling from one city to another with a number of other people. On the way a lion attacked them.

The lion killed several of the people, while the others ran away. But the princess was so beautiful that the lion fell in love with her. He came towards her with the tail waving and ears laid back. The princess without any fear stroked him

The lion, full of joy at his touch, allowed her to climb on his back and then he took her to his cave.

For many years they lived happily together. The princess had two children, a boy and a girl. She called the boy Sinhabahu or lion-armed and the girl Sinhasivali, or lion-maiden.

When he grew up, the boy Sinhabahu wanted to leave the cave when the lion was out hunting in the forest, to run away with his mother and sister. So one day, when the lion was out hunting in the forest, ran away with his mother and sister.

They roamed through the forest and at last, came to the princess' city. When the lion returned to the cave, he found it empty. His wife and children were gone. He looked for them in the forest, but in vain.

So the lion went from one city to another, looking for his wife and children. Wherever he went, the people left the city in fear of him.

After a long time, he came to the city, where his wife and children were now residing. The people of the city came and told the king that a lion was roaming around the city.

The king offered a grand monetary prize to anyone who would kill the lion. When no one came forward he increased the prize. Sinhabahu wanted to kill the lion, but three times his mother stopped him. Then, without telling his mother he went to the king and said, "I will kill the lion."

Sinhabahu took his bow and arrows and went out. When the lion saw him, he knew that it was his son.

So, he came towards the man full of love, waving his tail. But Sinhabahu shot an arrow. However, so great was the love of the lion that the arrow fell from his forehead without harming him.

Three times this happened. Then the lion became angry. Because of his anger, the next arrow pierced him and killed him. When Sinhabahu returned to the city, the king wanted to give him the kingdom. But he took his mother and sister and went away.

He built another city and called it Sinhapura, or Lion City.

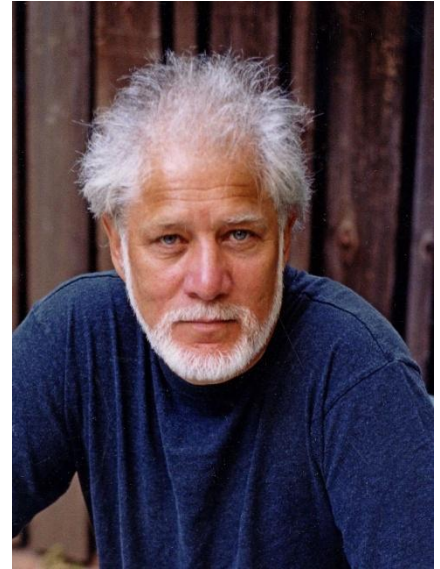
According to legend, King Vijaya, who arrived in Sri Lanka and established the Sinhalese race, is believed to be the son of Sinhabahu and Sinhasivali.



# Novel

## Sri Lankan English Novel Writers

1. Shehan Karunatilaka
2. Michael Ondaatje
3. Romesh Gunasekara
4. Nihal De Silva
5. Shyam Selvadurai





- **Shehan Karunatilaka**



Shehan Karunatilaka, born in 1975 in Galle, Sri Lanka, is a Sri Lankan writer and creative director whose career spans from 2000 to the present. He is known for writing in various genres, including novels, children's books, and short stories. His education includes time at S. Thomas' Preparatory School, Whanganui Collegiate School, and Massey University.

- **The Seven Moons of Maali Almeida**

The Seven Moons of Maali Almeida is a 2022 novel by Sri Lankan author Shehan Karunatilaka and the winner of the 2022 Booker Prize.

The novel was published on 4 August 2022 by the small independent London publisher Sort of Books. An earlier version of the novel was originally published in the Indian subcontinent as Chats with the Dead in 2020.

#### Summary

The novel is set in Sri Lanka in the 1980s, and written in the second person. The central character, Maali Almeida, is a dead photographer who sets out to solve the mystery of his own death and is given one week ("seven moons") during which he can travel between the afterlife and the real world. In this time, he hopes to retrieve a set of photographs, stored under a bed, and to persuade his friends to share them widely to expose the brutalities of the Sri Lankan Civil War.

## Background and Publication

Karunatilaka's second novel was written in various versions with different titles. The first draft was shortlisted for the Gratiaen Prize in 2015, where it was titled Devil Dance. It was originally published in the Indian subcontinent as Chats with the Dead in 2020 by Penguin India's Hamish Hamilton imprint.

Karunatilaka struggled to find an international publisher for the novel because most deemed Sri Lankan politics "esoteric and confusing" and many impenetrable, and difficult for Western readers. The independent British publishing house Sort of Books agreed to publish the novel after editing to "make it familiar to Western readers."

**Marks(Project)**

| Criteria     | Mark |  |
|--------------|------|--|
|              |      |  |
| Content      | 6    |  |
| Language     | 6    |  |
| Organization | 4    |  |
| Finishing    | 4    |  |
| Total        | 20   |  |

Date - .....

Signature of the Lecture - .....